

"A scholar could spend the rest of his life at the archives."

LOV VERMA, DIRECTOR-GENERAL, NATIONAL ARCHIVES



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THE VAULTS OF TIME

The imposing black gates shelter the buildings within from the noisy buses, honking cars and children selling magazines. Sleepy guards stand sentinel, protecting the brittle pages of the eras long forgotten by a modern India and remembered only by academics and researchers. They are the ones who haunt the National Archives, sifting through Nur Jehan's missives and reading Bhagat Singh's lawyer's notes during his trial. It's like touching history.

That's how Lov Verma, joint secretary of the Ministry of Culture, felt last December when he took over as Director-General of the archives. As he walks through the 75-km linear shelf space, looking at shelves of documents neatly classified, he picks up a random file. It dates back to 1791, a note on recruiting of forest officers who would be sent to France for training before being incorporated into the British service. "A scholar could spend the rest of his life there," he says.

Special permission is required to enter the archives.

Scholars wait for the documents they need to study in the library. Men and women, scattered through the aisles, masks on their faces, carefully catalogue sheets of paper, yellowed with age. One lakh maps and cartographic items are stored in the museum besides 1,000 documents of several treaties. The archives was located originally in Kolkata, says Assistant Director Rajesh Verma. "In 1911, the transfer of records began, which was completed in 1937. It took 26 years," he says. A museum showcases the oldest written documents in Persian dating back to October 1352. The conservation research laboratory at the archives that was set up in 1940 has also invented a process to protect weak, damaged paper. There's an attempt to make the archives more accessible to the public, to do away with its scholars-only approach. Until then, it will be the scholar, the academic and the sleepy guard who will come face to face with India's past, every day.

by Chitra Subramanyam